



SCAN TO VOTE

The annual Sportstar Aces Awards is back to honour a number of incredible performances across the spectrum of sports. Here are the nominations for two of the Popular Choice categories, Sportstar of the Year (Male) and Sportstar of the Year (Female). The voting lines are open till January 31.

Visit <https://sportstar.thehindu.com/aces-awards/popular-awards/>



SPORTSTAR OF THE YEAR (MALE)

Neeraj Chopra

Age: 26



Discipline: **Javelin throw**

A recurring groin injury saw Neeraj push himself harder than ever in the recently concluded season. He registered a throw of 89.45 metres in his only valid attempt in the Paris 2024 final, securing India back-to-back

Olympic medals. His effort may have fallen short of the monstrous 92.97m Olympic record throw that won Arshad Nadeem the title in the French capital, but Neeraj continued to flirt with the 90m mark throughout the year. He came closest at the Diamond League in Lausanne, where he fell merely 51cm short of the coveted mark. During the Paris Olympics qualification, he hurled the javelin 89.34m. On a couple of occasions, he was left to rue losses by the narrowest of margins – by 2cm against the Czech Republic's Jakub Vadlejch at the season-opening Doha DL and by a centimetre in the DL final at Brussels, where Grenada's Anderson Peters recorded an 87.87m throw to win the Diamond Trophy.

Achievements in the 2024 season:

- ✦ Won the Olympic silver medal
- ✦ Became the fifth individual multiple medallist for India at the Olympics
- ✦ Won gold at the Paavo Nurmi Games with a throw of 85.97m
- ✦ Finished as runner-up in the Diamond League final by a margin of 1cm

D. Gukesh

Age: 18



Discipline: Chess

D. Gukesh, once the second-youngest Grandmaster in history and now the third youngest overall, is among the most talked-about chess players globally. Hailing from Chennai, he began his chess journey at age seven after being introduced to the game in school. Within just six months, he became a FIDE-rated player.

Gukesh made headlines by becoming the third youngest player, following legends Bobby Fischer and Magnus Carlsen, to compete in the Candidates tournament. At 17, he also became the youngest winner of the tournament, an impressive achievement that cemented his place among the elite. Notably, Gukesh is the third-youngest player to achieve a rating of 2700 and the youngest ever to cross 2750. He is the first player to surpass Viswanathan Anand as India's top-ranked player in 37 years. He topped it all by becoming the youngest ever World Chess Champion, beating Ding Liren in a closely contested final.

Achievements in 2024 season:

- ✦ Became the youngest-ever World Chess Champion, beating Ding Liren in the final in Singapore
- ✦ Was the youngest player to win the Candidates Tournament in April 2024
- ✦ Won individual gold on Board 1 and team gold in the Open section of the Chess Olympiad 2024 in Budapest.
- ✦ Finished second behind Wei Yi in the Tata Steel Chess Masters 2024